



The mandrake legend

No other plant has such a reputation for magical, even demonic, powers as the mandrake. Its long root contains tropane alkaloid chemicals that can cause dizziness, a raised heart rate, and hallucinations. Witches were said to add it to potions in the hope that it would send them into a trancelike state or help them fly. More prosaically, the ancient Roman scholar Pliny told patients to chew it before surgery to dull pain, and in the medieval period it was highly valued as a medicinal herb.

However, mandrake owes much of its magical status to its oddly humanlike shape. The ancient Greek idea that plants could affect the body parts that they resembled persisted in the medieval period. The mandrake's shape was associated with both the male and the female body, so it was sought-after as an aphrodisiac and a cure for sterility. As well as fortune in love, people wore amulets made from its root to bring more general good luck.

The most famous legend linked to mandrake was that when pulled up, the root would utter a scream so terrible that it would kill anyone who heard it. Those in need of mandrake were advised to tie the root to a dog, so that it would pull up the plant and suffer the fatal curse. Here, the dog is lured by a bowl of food. Later legends held that mandrake would grow where a criminal was hanged or buried, nourished by the person's semen and urine, such tales earning it the nickname "little gallows man."

"Would curses kill as doth
the mandrake's groan ..."

WILLIAM SHAKESPEARE, *HENRY VI*, 1589–1592